

Sylvia Zuniga

szuniga2908@gmail.com | zunsyl.github.io/sylvia-zuniga.github.io | (619) 252-0526

Education

Master's of Science in Computational Social Science

Jun 2026 - Present

University of California, San Diego

Bachelor of Science in Cognitive Psychology

Aug 2021 - Jun 2025

Minor in Cognitive Science

University of California, San Diego

Jobs

Orthographic Transcription Team Lead

Jul 2025 - Aug 2026

DrivenData

Denver, Colorado (Remote)

- Supervised and organized a team of orthographic transcribers, optimizing team operations and communication
- Developed a high-quality dataset from children's speech samples to enhance Automatic Speech Recognition (ASR) model accuracy and training

Admin Intern

Jul 2025 - May 2026

Creating S.P.A.C.E.

Denver, Colorado (Remote)

- Streamlined file organization by implementing efficient management systems and introducing new organizational methods
- Researched and secured grant and conference opportunities to support program initiatives
- Directed social media and public relations strategies to expand outreach and engagement
- Collaborated with the marketing team and conducted interviews with people with disabilities to amplify their stories and promote inclusivity

AI Trainer - Psychology Expert

Sep 2025 - Jan 2026

Handshake MOVE Fellowship

(Remote)

- Developed and evaluated domain-specific prompts to assess the performance of large language models (LLMs) in Psychology
- Analyzed LLM outputs for scientific accuracy, clarity, and depth in specialized subfields
- Contributed to improving AI understanding of complex biological topics through expert

- review and feedback
- Conducted independent research to support prompt development and evaluation tasks

Awards

Chancellor's Associates Scholarship

Program (CASP)

Aug 2021 - Jun 2025

University of California, San Diego - Full Ride (~\$60,000)

Muir Honors - Caledonian Member

May 2025

Muir College

University of California, San Diego

Outstanding Scholar Presenter Award

May 2025

Psychology Department

University of California, San Diego

Triton Research & Experiential Learning Scholars (TRELS)

Jun - Aug 2024

University of California, San Diego - \$5,000

Best Presenter Award

May 2024

CSUSM 30th Annual Psychology Student Research Conference

California State University, San Marcos

Anderson Travel Award

Dec 2023

University of California, San Diego - \$200

Muir Student Travel Scholarship

Nov 2023

University of California, San Diego - \$300

IDEA Scholars Program

Jul 2021

Jacob's School of Engineering

University of California, San Diego - \$1,000

Quest Bridge

Sep 2020 - Dec 2022

2020 National College Match Application

Semi Finalist

Research Experience

Research Assistant

Jun 2023 - Jun 2025

Social Cognitive Development Lab, PI: Dr. Gail Heyman

University of California, San Diego

- Led two pioneering studies on ChatGPT, launched shortly after its release, to examine user behavior and the societal impacts of AI
- Developed coding schemes and conducted data categorization and analysis to advance research outcomes

- Authored abstracts and manuscripts to disseminate key study findings
- Mentored research assistants by providing constructive feedback to strengthen study design and execution

Review Team Lead

Jun 2023 - Jun 2025

Social Cognitive Development Lab

University of California, San Diego

- Collaborated with a research team to conduct literature reviews, peer reviews, pilot studies, and other tasks supporting senior lab projects
- Led and guided review sessions to strengthen lab research and information-gathering efforts
- Assigned and structured review tasks to ensure clarity, consistency, and alignment with project goals
- Monitored progress and secured timely completion of assignments to maintain research timelines

Research Summer Program Scholar

Jun - Aug 2024

Triton Research & Experiential Learning Scholars (TRELS)

University of California, San Diego

- Participated in a UC San Diego program offering hands-on experience in research, creative projects, and public service under faculty mentorship
- Collaborated with peers in weekly cohort meetings to share progress and refine project development
- Presented research findings through a formal slide presentation at an on-campus conference

Conference Presentations

Zuniga, S., Waltzer, T., & Heyman, G. D. (2025). Attitudes toward ChatGPT: A case study of ChatGPT adoption among student and non-student groups. Poster presented at the UC San Diego Mentored Undergraduate Research and Applied Learning Symposium, La Jolla, CA.

Zuniga, S., Waltzer, T., & Heyman, G. D. (2025). Attitudes toward ChatGPT: A case study of ChatGPT adoption among student and non-student groups. Poster presented at the Western Psychological Association annual convention, Las Vegas, NV.

Zuniga, S., Waltzer, T., & Heyman, G. D. (2024). Naturalistic research on ChatGPT experiences. *Talk presented at the University of California, San Diego Summer Research Conference, La Jolla, CA.*

Zuniga, S., Gabrenya, A., Waltzer, T., & Heyman, G. D. (2024). How is ChatGPT integrated into society following its release? Students and their new tool. *Poster presented at the CSUSM 30th Annual Psychology Student Research Conference, San Marcos, CA.*

Zuniga, S., Gabrenya, A., Waltzer, T., & Heyman, G. D. (2024). How is ChatGPT integrated into society following its release? Students and their new tool. *Poster presented at the Society for Personality and Social Psychology annual convention, San Diego, CA.*

Zuniga, S., Gabrenya, A., Waltzer, T., & Heyman, G. D. (2024). How is ChatGPT integrated into society following its release? Students and their new tool. *Poster presented at the University of California, San Diego Lab Expo, San Diego, CA.*

Academic Writing

Zuniga, S. (2024). Yes, but Also No: Ambivalence Towards ChatGPT During Its Initial Release. [Manuscript in review]

Zuniga, S. (2024). The role of attitudes in norm spreading: A case study of ChatGPT adoption among student and non-student groups. [Submitted for TRELS program]

Volunteering

Western Psychological Association Volunteer

May 2025

Western Psychological Association Annual Convention

Las Vegas, NV

- Ensure the security and proper use of badges for event access
- Assisted attendees with any badge-related questions or issues in a professional and courteous manner
- Collaborate with the event and facility staff to facilitate smooth badge operations and overall event flow

Development Volunteer

Feb 2025

University Development Office

University of California, San Diego

- Engaged high level scholarship donors in stewardship events
- Represented scholarship program with high degree of professionalism

Sun God Festival Volunteer

Apr 2022

Associated Students office of Concerts & Events (ASCE)

University of California, San Diego

- Directed photography operations for a student-run music and arts festival, documenting festival activities

Bear Gardens Volunteer

Apr - May 2022

Associated Students office of Concerts & Events (ASCE)

University of California, San Diego

- Volunteered at multiple student-run daytime carnivals, assisting with setup, cleanup, and overall event operations
- Hosted carnival games, music and photo stations, and supported attendees to ensure an engaging and enjoyable experience

Customer Service Volunteer

Sep 2019 - Sep 2020

Sharp Health Care, Chula Vista, California

- Supported patients at Sharp Hospital gift shop, providing assistance and enhancing interpersonal and professional communication

Vice President, Publicity Manager, and Volunteer

Jul 2019 - Mar 2020

Key Club Local Chapter, Hilltop High School

- Facilitated meetings and coordinated volunteering opportunities for the local Key Club chapter at Hilltop High School
- Designed digital and physical posters to promote community service initiatives and boost participation

Technology Manager and Volunteer

Jul 2019 - Mar 2020

Key Club International, State Chapter California

- Managed promotions of volunteering opportunities through digital posters and social media posts
- Created promotional materials for the State Chapter to enhance outreach and engagement

Activities

Member and Part of the Event Committee

May 2023 - Jun 2025

Psi Chi at the University of California, San Diego

- Participated in weekly meetings, engaging in professor spotlights and contributing to committees including research, business, events, volunteer, journal, and Psi BETA
- Assisted in planning and organizing events to promote professional engagement within the Psychology community

Member

Jul 2017 - Jun 2022

Society of Hispanic Professional Engineers (SHPE)

Local Chapter, Hilltop High School

- Leveraged available resources and networking opportunities to expand professional connections
- Participated in and hosted SHPE local chapter outreach events to engage the community and promote STEM initiatives

Vice President and Member

Jul 2017 - Jun 2021

Robotics Club at Hilltop High School

- Led meetings and directed decisions on volunteering and fundraising initiatives
- Designed, built, and programmed robots for VEX Robotics competitions (local and national) and the 2019–2020 FIRST Robotics Competition (FRC) in Del Mar, serving as robotics designer, safety captain, and mechanic

Additional Skills and Training

Languages: English (native fluency) and Spanish (native fluency)

Programming Languages: Python, R, MATLAB, HTML, git_bash

Software and Applications: Google Hub, Microsoft Office, VSCode, Jupyter Notebook, GitHub, Canva, CapCut, DaVinci Resolve, Open Broadcaster Software (OBS), MediBang Paint, Praat, Asana, Clockify, Slack

Training: Collaborative Institutional Training Initiative (CITI Program) for Social & Behavioral Research and Research Involving Children, Health Insurance Portability and Accountability Act (HIPAA) for Sharp Hospital

Updated August 2026